

hair near Delhi's RML Hospital.

Across the spectrum—from Habibullahs to Abids—Indian Muslims are experiencing an identity crisis. As India becomes the new battleground of radical Islam, there seems to be no shortage of young Muslim rebels who are waiting for their martyrdom moment. Jihadi chic is in. The recent bomb blasts that rocked India and the subsequent arrests and deaths in police encounters have brought out not only the face of religious terror but the anxiety of an entire community as well. Suddenly, for many Indian Muslims, their religion has become a badge of suspicion. In the noisy atmosphere of stereotyping and caricaturing, many Muslims feel they themselves are being branded and stigmatised for the crime of a minuscule. They feel angry, anxious, and ashamed.

The otherness of being a Muslim is all too familiar now. "Apart from close friends, there is a sense of suspicion. There is a bit of difficulty in making new friends and communicating with them. One of the reasons for this is: people do not have a good understanding of what is going on and all sort of stories are being floated," says Mujibur Rahman, a social scientist from Jamia Millia Islamia. Sharifa Khanam, an activist and the founder member of STEPS, an organisation fighting for empowerment of women in Chennai still remembers her experience on the eve of the last Independence Day, when she travelled to Bangalore by train from Chennai. "I just opened my plastic carry bag to search for a balm. My co-

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passengers gave me a strange look. Just because I am a Muslim, I feel, I am mentally and physically spied upon."

Words turned heavy for K.K. Shahina, a freelance journalist who moved to Delhi from Kerala last year, after her article in a media portal was plagiarised by the Indian Mujahideen activists to liven up terror e-mail, leading the police on her trail. "One of the top officials we met during the course of this, asked, 'So, you're a Muslim?' I gave him no answer," says Shahina, an agnostic, born to Muslim parents. "Am I doing wrong by turning my back on the millions of innocent people who follow religion, bearing the brunt of what has been done in the name of religion?" she asks.

IN THE CROSSFIRE:
For many Muslims, their religion has become a badge of suspicion

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



Arakkal, a Bangalore-based artist.

India is home to the second largest Muslim population in the world. Their ghettoisation continues to be exploited by votebank politics. So the M-word has to be used with utmost political care. That is why, as India emerges as the softest target of the radical rage, there is no national consensus on identifying the enemy or naming it. What we have in abundance are lazy generalisations and empty political rhetoric. Minister of State for External Affairs E. Ahmed says Muslims need not react angrily to this stereotyping. "I am sure this is a passing phase," he says.

As Muslims say, *Insha Allah*. God willing.

with Farzand Ahmed, Uday Mahurkar, Senthil Kumar and bureau reports